



Easter Egg

— LOSING HIS WIFE —

KT MORRISON

EASTER EGG

A LOSING HIS WIFE EPILOG

KT MORRISON

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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EASTER EGG

A Losing His Wife Epilog

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EASTER EGG

THIS IS A HIDDEN FANTASY SHORT INVOLVING MY MOST BELOVED CHARACTERS. IT'S AN EPILOGUE (OR PERHAPS A PROLOGUE OF SORTS), FEATURING PETE AND JESS MAPPLETHORPE FROM THE FIRST LOSING HIS WIFE SERIES. IT MAY BE REAL OR IT MAY NOT . . .

Wednesday, April 8th

Pete ran across Conway Street where it met Water, and then did a loop around the brass statue of Ellie Callou, the town of Peavey Falls' noted suffragette. 5 A.M. and fifty-five degrees out, and while it was spring, the time and temperature and his own body heat were enough to send roiling clouds of frosty breath from him. But his feet tapped away. Not afraid of the cold. He ran every day, even the sunny ones.

The Peavey 10K Run for Charity was two weeks away. Raising money for the St. Joan of Arc Hospital's pediatric unit. He'd logged more than fifty 10Ks over the winter, one day at a time. Pretty much got himself *over*-prepared but these morning runs were for therapy more than fitness anyway.

And most of his best ideas were born on these runs. The idea to integrate scaleable inventory management services controlled by Save-Mart but accessible by key vendors. Check. The sudden sale of their first Cleveland home, upscaling themselves into a nicer neighborhood (where prices had remained fixed) with their gains. Check. The hire of three young unpaid interns from the college, forming a vendor outreach program with them and giving them accreditation. Check. Even simple things like planning a Christmas get-together with Patty and Russ, a rapprochement in the midway point between Cleveland and Columbus, and even trading in the Oldsmobile and getting the Tahoe. Well, that wasn't a *good* idea. That was kind of stupid. A waste of money. The smile though on Jess's face was worth it. And the boys? ...They thought old pop was real swell when they pulled up to the rink on Saturday mornings for hockey practice in that luxury truck. But he bought it two years old, depreciation hit already gone, and they scaled down to one vehicle.

He hated giving in to the lure of extravagances but living in a nicer neighborhood came with its responsibilities. He didn't want people talking about Andy and Petey's cheap old weird dad. They'd been through enough. The more the appearance of stability the better.

He came to a red light and jogged in place at the edge of the crosswalk. Traffic was sparse so early in the morning, but there were cars out, headlights on, people embarking on their dim commute on an early Wednesday morning. He unzipped his phone and flipped the screen to see if he had any news. He was Save-Mart's Divisional Merchandise Manager now. A VP, in charge of maintaining merchandising relationships with Save-Mart's prime suppliers all over the northeast; Mid-west to Cleveland to the Canadian border to the Atlantic and down to the Mason-Dixon. Today was his presentation to Porter Papers which sold just about every paper product under Save-Mart's roof, from tissues and toilet paper to plates and packaging. It was a no-brainer, and just a bit of hand-holding. The execs at

Porter were just as gushing to Pete at how they were represented in Save-Mart stores. Only, he'd sent an e-mail to Becky last night to get a preview of the changes to the Powerpoint and she hadn't got back to him. He didn't need to worry but he did anyway. Becky was new. Pretty and flirty and he hated to have to discipline her. So many of these kids today never got back to you after hours even though he knew they got the messages. They were always on their goddamn phones. The light changed and he headed onto the crosswalk early, slipping his message-less phone into his pocket.

There was a raucous horn that scared the shit out of him. An aggressive pickup truck looming in height and muscle charged him, nose diving, rubber chirping and horn bellowing. He put his hand out, his heart pounding in his chest. The horn continued angrily. *All right, already, sorry!* His hand rested on the mouth of the lifted truck's grill. He waved to the driver, it was his fault, avoided eye contact and trotted off again, trying to find his pace. By the time he hit Peavey Street, looking over the railing and down to the white thrashing water of the falls, he'd shaken off the jangled nerves and his thoughts were back on work.

The Mapplethorpe family Tahoe gleamed in the driveway of their Holly Springs white clapboard suburban Colonial. Forty-five hundred square feet with a fully finished lower level that opened onto a hilly green lawn where the boys would play. A large lot on a cul-de-sac, with a gravel trail behind the house, hidden by trees, that wound around a pond and led to the Holly Springs community pool and tennis courts.

He was cooling down, shaking his legs out as he walked the driveway then up the path between two towering lilac shrubs, their buds just starting to blossom. He hid his keys when he left, slipping them on a hook hidden under the backyard deck, on a joist behind the cedar ledger. Trotted up onto

the deck on springy new Sauconys, between the two iron patio tables he'd brought out of storage on Sunday but hadn't got the chairs around or an umbrella into yet. He'd get to it tonight. Get the furniture out, get it cleaned. Spring was here and company was coming.

Got the smallest key on the ring into the sliding glass door lock and opened it, slipped into the kitchen as quietly as he could. Kicked his shoes off and left them there on the rubber mat next to Sargent's water bowl. Sargent, the lone woken member of the household—black eyes watching old Pete from his wicker dog bed, too early for anything more enthusiastic than a lazy swishing wag from the feathers at the tip of his tail.

The coffeemaker began to hiss on the counter, programmed to be at the ready for when the family got up. He checked his watch. It was early but he might still have time.

The stairs could creak even though the house wasn't that old, so he slipped along the edges where they met the wall, making no sounds in his socks. At the top of the stairs he turned right, headed between the boys' doors and made it to the master bedroom.

Last night Jess had taught her dance class down in the village at the Peavey Falls Little Theater. She taught on Tuesdays and Thursdays, her class had an age range of little girls (and one brave little boy) between eight and twelve years old. Pete had the boys and baby Annabelle last night. Class was out by eight but she went out for a drink with some friends and she didn't get home until ten.

He slipped in the double doors and locked them behind him. Jess was sleeping where he'd left her when he woke at 4:30 and headed out for his run. Sleeping on her belly, her long blonde hair tangled around her on her pillow. Head turned to the center, looking at his pillow, looking at where he would be if he were still warm in bed with her. Her arms held a deep tan. One week with the boys and Annabelle in Orlando had given her a very

sexy color. One wonderful week with the love of his life, (no work!) and his boys, and his baby.

Skated quietly then in his sock across the hard maple floor and into the master bathroom. Brushed his teeth quickly and rinsed with Scope. Peeled the tight running clothes off and threw them in the hamper. So cold outside his penis was just an acorn in his pubic hair, his testicles gone, hiding up in his body. Didn't tug it, just let it be. Took a bath towel and he dried himself off, his skin cold, but a chilly sweat on the surface. She would complain.

He'd been in the mood last night but exhausted. Watched Ghostbusters with the boys down in the TV room, baby Annabelle asleep in her crib, baby monitor on the coffee table. After the movie Petey took Andy up to bed and he tried to stay awake for Jess but he fell asleep on the couch. Went to bed before ten, heard her come home shortly after that, wake him up, and by then it was too late.

He was still in the mood. Not even a quarter to six and he wanted a piece of his wife before he had to go to work and deal with the suits from Porter.

Their bedroom faced over the yard, their bed a maple sleigh under a cathedral ceiling that formed a bank of bay windows. He slipped naked into the bed, lifting the bedding and getting in right next to her from her side.

She moaned softly, feeling him coming, then hissed and jumped.

"Pete!"

Her legs kicked back from him, recoiled. He bounced himself under the sheets and covered up, soaking in the warmth from the bedding where she'd just been laying.

"You're freezing," she said, turning now, her face very mad, hair tangled over her, caught in the wet of her lips.

"I didn't know," he laughed, "I don't feel cold."

He didn't. Not until he settled into her warm spot and realized how good it felt.

“Why would you do that?” Her eyes were closed again and she lay with her face turned to the ceiling, a hand rubbing her cheeks.

“I missed you last night,” he said.

“Mm, I know. You were asleep when I got home.”

“Did you have fun?”

“Yeah,” she said.

“Who was there?”

“Uh, Shelly from Peavey Public, she brought a friend who’s a mom of one of my students—”

“From dance?”

“Mm,” she moaned and stretched, rubbing her eyes, “Yeah, from the dance class, her daughter’s pretty good.”

“Who else?”

“Uh, Rose from yoga, and Marnie.”

“I know Marnie.”

“You do.”

“Hey, I’m going to touch you...”

“You better not,” she said, blinking, letting her eyes get adjusted to being awake.

“Come on, Jess, warm me up,” he said, refraining from reaching out and touching her like he wanted.

She sighed and smiled and wormed her way closer to him, but kept a space between them.

“You sex maniac,” she said.

“I tried to stay awake last night but I was so tired.”

“Why do you go to bed so early?”

“Because I get up so early.”

“It’s that cold out this morning?” she said, looking in his eyes.

“Feel how cold,” he said, smiling back.

Her hands were folded up on the pillow under her cheek and he took one by a wrist and led it under the covers. She watched his eyes as she felt around his shriveled penis. She touched it, her fingers tweaked his tip and jiggled it.

“Where did it go?” she said.

“Warm it up for me.”

She pulled it, and gripped it, tried to squeeze it in her warm hand. When she felt lower, she said, “Pete, your balls...”

“I know.”

“They’re gone, Petey.”

“Kiss me,” he said.

“You got to brush your teeth, I didn’t...” she giggled and she kissed his shoulder.

“Come on, Jess,” he said, pleading warmly with his eyes.

“Your hands are like ice,” she said, still tugging at his shrunken size.

“Your mouth is warm,” he said.

She smiled and narrowed her eyes at him. Took the sheets then and wrapped them around herself, protecting her bare arms from touching his skin. She slipped under the blanket and he watched her ghostly shape move down between his legs. Her mouth went over his little penis and his eyes closed at her lovely warmth. The whole thing went past her lips, his raisin scrotum, his quickly hardening cock. She sucked, bobbed, his flaccid genitals entirely in her mouth. As he grew hard, as his cock stuck out from his body he peeled the cover up so he could watch her.

“Hey,” she said, catching his eye, and then frowning.

“Let me watch you,” he said.

Her heart pendant lay flat on his thigh and her hands rested on his trim belly. He put a hand over one. She grinned for him, held his erection between her fingers and slipping his tip along her bottom lip. She left his

eyes and sunk his little thing in her mouth and sucked again, bobbed and fed off his reactions. He grew to steel in just a minute.

Her thumb and forefinger went gently up and down, and she said, “Did you lock that door?”

“I did.”

“Get me in the mood?”

He nodded, feeling excitement tighten his ribs.

“Don’t touch me with your cold,” she giggled as she lay back and he took *his* turn under the covers. Her knees drew up and he got between her legs. Her warmth radiated from the flesh between her thighs and he was careful not to freeze her with his coldest parts. His shoulder touched the inside of her knee and she flinched but she didn’t protest.

She was wearing a white undershirt and black cotton panties and he slipped his fingers into her waistband, keeping the contact with her sensitive belly to a minimum. He pulled them up her thighs and her knees rose above his head, came together to a point and he hooped them over and then down her calves. He smelled her. She was warm and sleepy and she smelled like his Jess. He tasted her. Just his face touching her.

His tongue swept her wrinkled folds and she began to moan in anticipation. Two fingers came up and touched her in her center where she was so hot his cold was extinguished. His fingers parted like a V and he spread her, kissed her at the warm wet inside of her labia, his tongue starting to curl and point and penetrate. She moaned more loudly and her hips started to rock. The deeper her breaths grew the closer he came to her hood and when he had her breaths scoring and her hips writhing he took her swollen clit. He worked it and his finger gently caressed and plunged ever so slightly. He brought her up slowly, let her body tell him what it wanted. He responded, kissing and suckling and stroking and lunging, giving her what she needed, advancing when she did, receding when she wanted. Hard strokes and delicate tickles until those breathes became whines and he felt

her nails in his hair. There was a tremble in her thrusts as she ground her hips into his driving tongue.

When she got like this he wondered if she thought of the other man. He thought she must. That she would do it to take herself over the edge. He didn't mind if she did, just don't tell him. He imagined it, but he didn't want to know for sure.

He felt safest with Jess when he was between her legs like this. Or if he took her from behind. Sometimes it hurt him to look in her eyes when they made love. *Most* of the time it hurt—it hurt to see her face in ecstasy because it made him think of bad things. Not *all* the time, just when things were stressful or he was feeling down.

“Pete, Pete,” she whispered and her hands left him. His eyes wandered up her belly, up over her breasts pressing against the white undershirt and saw her face turned to the ceiling, her hands over her head and clutching the top of the polished sleigh. She was going to come. Closed his eyes then and he gulped her. Took all her hot wet flesh in his mouth and pulled it, sucked it into him, tongue driving, flexed and curled, the strong base of it riding her bucking clit. She gasped, and the headboard banged, and her hips thrust up against him. She tightened and twisted and she held her breath.

She turned to her side, ass still flat on the bed, but spun at the waist holding a pillow clutched over her face as she groaned into it. He kissed his way through her bushy pubic hair, up her flat belly, and ran his tongue over her belly button like a pool ball being drained. He pressed his cold body to her and she inhaled sharply and said something into the pillow. He held her, took her heat from her and she didn't fight him.

He fixed his penis inside her. She was hot and wet still, so slick, and his small size slipped right up. His fingers clutched into the pillow, pulled it from her face. She turned her head too, and he didn't try and look in her eyes. He fucked her missionary with his face buried in her collar. Sucked on her neck and along her clavicle, and she rubbed his back, waiting for him to

come. Her knees came up and she clasped them to his waist. She was soundless. Just his breaths rushing as he got closer and closer to orgasm, dry burgeoning desperate sounds as his semen began to boil in his balls hiding somewhere inside his body.

He closed his eyes and pictured her out last night with friends. His bad Jessy. There was a guy who brought his daughter to her class that hung around sometimes. Single dad. A mechanic down at Ray's Auto Shop. He was a good dad, burly, big gut, friendly smile but dazzling icy blue eyes and white teeth. He pictured Jess lying last night. Meeting him, whatever his name was. Maybe she didn't know his name. Maybe she just took him behind the Theater, down the walkway that looked out over the Peavey River and he fucked her from behind, bent her over the metal railing, the rushing river drowning out her cries of passion.

"You, uh...off your...pill?"

"Yeah, I...I stopped..."

"You ovulating?"

"Close...You going to give me an-another baby?"

"Tell me...Jess, tell me you want my baby..."

Her hand rubbed his back as he humped his little cock inside her hard and fast with short earnest strokes.

"That's it, Petey," she cooed in his ear, "Give me a little baby, I want another little baby..."

He stabbed her, stabbed her as hard as he could and he made her grunt with each one. She felt him coming. Could feel his seed shooting out of him. He grunted and groaned and thrust himself into her, trying to get that seed of his as deep as he could. He'd give her another baby. If it kept her in the house, he'd keep her full of babies.

Pete came downstairs after his shower to his family in motion. The boys were at the kitchen table and Jess was at work in the wide space between the island and the stove, weaving around toys and Sargent, who was following her and almost purposely trying to get in her way. Annabelle was on her knees, three-years-old now, blonde hair, long and silky and light like Jess's. Pete pulled the latch on the baby gate that crossed the door from the hall into the mouth of the spacious kitchen. When he closed it behind him, Jess turned and smiled and she squat right down on her heels next to Annabelle and said, "Who's that?"

She lifted a finger and pointed it to Pete as Annabelle turned, one hand on her Peppa Pig, the other on Peppa's piggy husband, George. She had her Peppa's Deluxe Playhouse hinged open on the bleached maple floor, pig tables and chairs, and a bright yellow clawfoot tub scattered at its base. Her face brightened, eyes went wide when she saw Pete and she worked her way to her feet and ran to him, saying, "Daddy!"

Annabelle came to him, sure-footed these days, and Jess patted her bottom before she went. He squat down too, just across from Jess and held his hands out for his daughter. She fell into them and he hoisted her as he stood and plopped her against his chest and kissed her cheek. Annabelle launched into a story and while it made no sense to him, (he thought it might have been about the Pig family) she was enthusiastic and lively and had a flare for drama. He nodded and said, "Oh, really?" at appropriate points. Jess pressed herself against him in her robe, kissed Annabelle's cheek too, and sneakily patted Pete's bottom so the boys wouldn't see.

"Eggs?" she asked.

"The works," he said, seeing she had bacon and sausage on paper towels, and buttered toast.

"How you want yours?" she asked as she returned to the stove and Pete walked with Annabelle on his hip to the kitchen table where the boys were

getting themselves together with their breakfast. Andy was bringing Petey's tablet to him, watching something on the screen and stumbling along.

"Scrambled, Jess," he said, then to Andy, "Come on buddy, come and sit, please."

"Petey, buddy, what's with the long face, kid?"

Petey said, "My face isn't long, Dad." He frowned, swiped the tablet that Andy had brought him, his long lashes blinking while he watched his fingers manipulate the screen.

"Buddy..." he said.

"Yeah?" he said, looking up now.

"You're going to cream those Tigers, you know."

"I know, Dad," he said. He was worried. This was a big weekend coming up. He had his Aunt Patty, Uncle Russ, and cousins coming, they would be attending his Saturday morning hockey game and that was giving him stress. He was pushed to the limit already with his team. It was Peewee hockey, but the coach was straight NHL. Hammering plays into them, making them memorize complicated strategies while some of them were not even competent skaters or puck-handlers. Left Wing Locks, forechecking, face-off strategies... Petey was a good player, getting lanky this year, shooting up just before his tenth birthday. He was tall, uncoordinated, but a fast skater. Coach was throwing him into a lot of plays because he knew he could get to spots fast, but the anxiety of accepting the puck was working his poor son, making him tense. Some of the other parents had complained about the stress, but Coach Harrison hadn't changed. He was young. A real bearded hothead and he was the kind of guy who didn't know any other way to do things than the way he already did them. There weren't many games left in the season any way.

"Here, Pete," Jess said, coming over to the table holding a plate with one piece of raisin toast spread with peanut butter on it. It had been cut in half then in narrow strips.

He made an excited face for Annabelle and said, “What did mommy bring for you? Your favorite...you want some? ...” He took a corner piece of the warm bread, held it by the crust and swooped it towards her talking mouth and she paused her story.

He paused too, said, “What do you say?”

She smiled and squinted hard like she was going to sneeze, didn’t, then said, “Yes, peez.”

“You are so smart,” he said and he kissed her head and she took the toast into her mouth.

“Okay, Annie, let’s get you in your spot,” he said then, and he took her and lifted her into her high chair, holding her by her armpits and dangling her legs into the chair’s holes. Set her down, got her situated with her toast in front of her and sat back at the table, in time for Jess to bring him his breakfast.

He looked up at the clock on the wall above the archway that led into the laundry room. It was after seven now, almost a quarter after. He scorfed his eggs, and washed it back with coffee.

Petey, said, “Dad, you’re eating too fast, you’re gonna choke.”

“Mmn-mm,” he shook his head, felt a crisp piece of bacon stick to the back of his throat and cleared it, felt it shoot up and hit the roof of his mouth. He coughed and his eyes watered.

Petey laughed and said, “I told you so,” and went back to his tablet.

There was a sound in the hall, someone coming in to their house and Jess watched the dining room where she could see through to the hall, watching to see who it was though they knew who it would be.

Stuart Tillman, neighbor and also a Save-Mart exec, lived down the street and they walked to the train together in the mornings. He was the same age as Pete but he didn’t get up early in the mornings to run and he also didn’t watch what he ate. He was a big guy, he carried his weight well, but he filled his suit out pretty good.

“Hey, Jessy,” he said and he kissed Jess’s cheek as he came into the kitchen, stepping over the baby gate instead of opening it. “Petey, Petey,” he said, looking at Pete trying to stuff a sausage in his mouth while he stood up, coffee cup poised to wash it all down. “Let’s go, chop chop,” he joked.

Pete nodded and Jess said, “Stuart, you want a cup of coffee, can you sit for a minute?”

Pete shook his head no, drinking his coffee, his other hand lifting his short juice glass.

“That’s all right, Jess,” Stuart said, “I had one already. I’m flying high as it is.”

Pete knocked his juice back and looped around the table, kissing the top of Annie’s head and dodging her peanut butter hands as they reached for him, tried to grab his tie. He kissed Petey on his hair, Andy too, then crossed the kitchen to Jess and Stuart. He stepped between Stuart and her, took her in his arms and kissed her for real and she leaned back with him, one foot coming off the floor. He caressed the small of her back, dipping a little low for public. He got her laughing and she pulled from him and wiped her mouth.

“You taste like bacon,” she laughed, then darted in and kissed his cheek and he winked.

“See you tonight,” he said

“By-eye,” she said, with exaggerated desire for him to get the hell out of here.

“Bye, boys, bye Annie,” he said waving from the baby gate. They waved back, Petey not looking up from his tablet. He and Stuart headed out their front door.

They walked down the cul-de-sac and made their way to the Holly Springs boardwalk that would take them across the marsh on a wooden bridge, a shortcut that would bring them into the Village in time to grab the train to Cleveland. As their feet hit the pressure-treated planks, Stuart turned

to him and said, “You’re one lucky guy, Pete. That Jess is something. You got a real great family.”

“Thanks,” he said. “They’re everything to me. I’d do anything for them.”

Jess got the boys fed, helped them clean up after themselves and walked them to the end of the cul-de-sac and got them on the bus. It was still such an odd feeling to get used to. Standing with the mothers of other children, waving at the school bus full of kids, then turning around and going home to her quiet house, alone but for baby Annie.

She was taking a break from teaching, taking a break from a lot of things since they moved to Cleveland. She’d had her baby, her beautiful little Annabelle. Then took time to stay at home with her and run the house. Pete had settled in at the corporate office and within eighteen months he was promoted to a VP position in charge of vendor relations. It just worked out well with her not going back to work. There had been the new house to be bought, and all the work that comes with that. She was doing well staying at home.

So if Pete wanted another baby that was fine for her. She would love another little one. She could always pick up substituting in a few years and try and get back in the swing then if she wanted.

Frankly, she was enjoying being at home so much with the kids. Planning their schedules, helping with their homework, making meals. Her little babies were getting well-prepared when they were receiving the full attention of a very organized Teacher of the Year.

For an hour after her family had left she cleaned. Vacuumed, ran the dishwasher, and put on a load of laundry, folded one that just came out of

the dryer. Then she took Annie up to the master bathroom with her and she got herself in the tub.

This Colonial they were in was luxurious and spacious. Even nicer than the home she'd grown up in. It wasn't even that expensive. Pete was so good with money that they were able to get themselves into this quaint little neighborhood in one of the nicest spots outside the city without a blink from the bank. They'd be paying for this place until they were sixty but it was really feeling like home.

The tub she took her bath in every morning was a freestanding oval under a tall window that looked out over the front lawn. She had a leafy palm on either side and it was like her spa break every day. The tub was even heated, she could lay her back against it and let the warmth work through her back, her neck, and her shoulders. Annie lay for a nap in her crib and Jess could watch her from the baby monitor she left at the end of the counter near the foot of the tub.

Once she was cleaned and dressed she bundled little Annie up and got her into her car seat in the back of the Tahoe and she headed to the Kroger. There was shopping to do for this weekend and she'd been dreading it. They had company coming and, while she was excited, it was still tough. She'd been trying to patch the relationship with Patty. Patty hated her. Had physically threatened her twice when Pete and she had got back together. Had fought and cried with her own brother for taking her back when she had a big round belly, another man's baby in it.

How can you do this to yourself, Pete?

She was right. Pete was a special man. She told that to Patty. Cried and poured her heart out how sorry she was and how good her brother was. It was met with stone. It wasn't until this last Christmas that they'd tried to get together. Enough time had passed, she thought. Though, how much was enough time considering what she'd done? There wasn't enough time. It would never be forgotten. All of them would just have to get over it.

As she got out to Orange Street she signaled right to get out to the highway, then changed her mind, easing the big SUV through the intersection at an awkward angle, turning across two lanes and then heading west along Orange Street and into the Village. It was all right, no cops around, and the pickup truck behind her did the same thing, butt itself right up to her bumper. No one honked. She would go to the Heinlens instead of the Kroger. Pete hated it when she shopped at the grocer in the Village because it was so expensive but they just had nicer things and she wanted this weekend to make a good impression on Patty.

This Christmas Pete had broken his sister down and they'd spent Christmas Eve together at a restaurant. It went well. There was nothing left to say. Small uncomfortable talk for sure, but no bad words were exchanged, though Patty's eyes shot black daggers at her. She was on her best behavior. She wanted Pete to be happy. Wanted his sister in their son's lives.

The biggest fear she had going in was that Patty and Russ would bring gifts for Petey and Andy but bring nothing for Annie. That would have killed her. That would have made her cry. But they didn't. They were thoughtful. It was a sign of hope. Maybe Pete had told them it was possible Annie was his. It was possible. Highly unlikely. Given the circumstances, which she hated to consider, that baby was not her husband's.

Old Pete never missed a step. He took Annie as his own. Sometimes, especially in those first few months back together, she would lay at night and cry at how forgiving he was. At what a good man he was. When Annie was born he treated her as he treated his own sons when they were born. He doted, he changed diapers, he got up at three in the morning and let her sleep. She was very lucky to have her family.

With Annie kicking her legs, dangling out of the slots in the seat of the shopping cart, Jess poked through the selections of appetizer trays. She got an antipasto platter, charcuterie and artisan cheeses, and one with grilled veggies and a peppercorn ranch dip. She bought the roast beef and some chicken breasts and a ham for Easter dinner. Stocked up on vegetables and some lunch meat for the boys, black forest ham for Pete.

She bought chocolate eggs and some bunnies for the kids so they could hide them on Easter morning and bought some eggs they could decorate. She'd already gone down to the Michaels just outside the city on Monday and bought all sorts of colored paper, felts, dyes, packs of cartoon eyes, and pipe cleaners and paints and egg decorating kits. She had a whole host of activities planned for the kids on Saturday afternoon and Sunday.

The lineup was long and she had to wait forever with her packed cart. The Heinlens was in the Village, an awkward sort of spot and had cramped aisles but it was nicely decorated and they carried better quality things. Usually it was quiet and they almost always had enough employees present, but three days before Easter it was very busy. She scrolled through her phone, played peek-a-boo with Annie who laughed and giggled and then said *mom-mom-mom*, over and over and when Jess said *What?* she launched into a long tale that at times made sense then other times really didn't—the whole while she kept Jess engaged with her enormous crystal blue eyes. She caught the attention of an older woman in the next line over and made her laugh.

She said, "How old?"

Jess said, "She's three," and the woman said *Gosh, she looks just like you, she's so pretty*. Jess laughed and said *Thank you*. Then in the silence after the exchange her smile faded and she felt suddenly very sad and very scared. She didn't know why. A rolling torpor, a sadness tinged with dread.

She looked up around the grocery, felt like she was watched, felt guilty for some reason.

She felt better in the fresh air.

Pushed the cart with Annie in it to the Tahoe, got her groceries loaded, stacked her cart through the others against the supermarket brick, and walked Annie back on her hip to the truck. Stopped at a Starbuck's drive-thru on the way home and got herself an iced cappuccino hoping the cold would settle her stomach.

Patty and Russ would be driving to Cleveland from Columbus on Friday afternoon, staying over Friday night and Saturday night. She had two guest rooms made up for them. One for Patty and Russ, one for Tammy, she figured Jacob might want to be in with the boys but that was up to him. If he wanted his own space there was a pull out couch in Pete's office. They had Petey's hockey game on Saturday morning and then afterward there was a farm out on the edge of Peavey Falls that was offering a fun Easter Egg Hunt and they would go to that. Dinner on Saturday night, that would be their Easter dinner, she was prepared for that. Then an Easter Egg Hunt of their own on Sunday morning, then a brunch (she'd shopped for that too), and hopefully there would be peace when they left on Sunday afternoon. Hopefully there would be another stitch in the tear in her husband's relationship with his sister. She'd ripped it. She was responsible. She liked to help mend it.

Once home, she backed up the driveway and unloaded the groceries through the garage, put on some music and started thinking about what she would do for dinner. She got a pot boiling to cook potatoes and had the fridge open when she thought she heard the front door open.

Annie was behind her, banging plastic pigs together in front of her open playhouse. She heard it too. She looked up and smiled and said, “Daddy.”

“Don’t think so,” Jess whispered and her hands went cold. No one came through their front door except Stuart. He wouldn’t come here now.

She listened, held onto the fridge door and strained to hear.

There were footsteps in the hall. Someone was in her house.

He stood in the hall of their home like he’d only been away for days. A photo of Annabelle held in his hand, lifted from the table that sat below the angled slash of stairs leading up to the bedrooms.

“Tyler,” she whispered and fell down in a dining room chair.

He smiled and set the frame back where he’d found it, turned then and put his hands in the pockets of his pants, said, “Hi, Jess.”

He wore a suit. No tie, just a jacket and pants and an unbuttoned white shirt. His hair was much the same, thick sandy brown and combed off his handsome face.

She was steel. Her insides churning molten metal. Her mouth opened to say something and she had no air. The hinge of her jaw worked but no voice came out and she didn’t even know what to say.

His shoes made hollow sound against the polished wood as he came to the step into the dining room. He looked around her home. Annabelle babbled, *Daddy* from the kitchen, behind her baby gate.

She stood, unsteady benumbed movement on languid legs; she still had failed to breathe. He stepped down, fixing his eyes on hers, that smile still there. She stepped back wordlessly. He stepped again and she took another one backward. Her back pressed to a six foot tall mirror fixed to the wall, it’s gilded frame touching her calves, her shoulder blades to the glass.

She exhaled, then whispered, “Don’t.”

But he came to her, a smirk twisting his mouth, his head cocked, studying her as he took the final steps to bring them together, face to face. One hand in his pocket still, he leaned the other against the mirror above her head, she looked up into his blue eyes.

“It’s been a long time, Jess,” he said, his breath whispering against her cheek.

“What are you doing here?” she sighed.

“I’m here to see you.”

“Don’t, Tyler. Get out.”

He laughed, his eyes never leaving hers. “I think about you all the time, Jess. I think—”

“Stop, Tyler,” she said.

“Every time I come through Ohio—anytime someone says the word Ohio—it...” he made a fist and punched the center of his chest, “it gets me, Jess.”

“I don’t want you here,” she said, her hand coming to her chest and closing the lapels of her open shirt.

His face got closer, he loomed over her, his eyes boring into hers. A slight smile tugged at those plump lips. He was clean-shaven, he smelled of leather and spice.

“Don’t,” she said.

He touched her thigh. His big hand smoothed the front of her left thigh, working higher. She shivered.

“Tyler, please...”

“Turn for me, Jess...”

“What?”

“Face the mirror.”

Facing away was easier than facing him and she turned on shaky feet, her house slippers working in little circles and she faced the mirror. She saw herself with him. His handsome face looming over her shoulder. Confident

and masculine. Filling out his suit jacket, the ridge of his muscular chest evident under his dress shirt.

She whispered, "What are you doing here?"

"I think about you every day, Jess. Today's the day I came for you."

His hand went to her hip, and her eyes lowered to it, watching in the mirror. The backward letters of LIVE on the first knuckles of his fingers. FREE would be on the other hand, the one still pressed over her shoulder against the mirror. She had the same phrase, his phrase, tattooed below her breast, pretty script across her ribs.

The hand slipped around her, coming to her tummy and then fixing its grip on the buckle of her belt. He worked the leather out of the pewter, let the two ends hang and he undid the top button of her pants.

"Take them down for me, Jess," he whispered in her ear.

"I'm not going to do that, Tyler," she said, fixing his gaze now over her shoulder looking at his reflection in the mirror.

His hand slipped under her waistband and he pushed her zipper down with the back of his hand as his fingers stroked over top of her panties.

She pushed his hand away, and yelled, "Tyler!" She spun then, faced him, looking up in his yes, his real eyes. She said, "Get out of my house."

He rested his hand on her collar, his thumb stroking her clavicle. "I've missed you, Jess."

"Don't lie to me."

"We had something."

"Pete will be home soon," she said.

"No, he won't. He doesn't come home for lunch. Doesn't even have a car. What's he going to do, take the train home for lunch? He won't be home until after six. We've got a long time. We've got all afternoon. A lot of catching up to do."

He leaned to kiss, his lips poised to take hers and she turned away from him. He kissed her neck, kissed her just below her ear. She put her hands on

him, one on his chest, the other touched his neck, felt that familiar strength, that hard feel of the man who she'd almost ruined her life for. The boy.

"I'll call...the police," she gasped.

His face changed, his hand came off the wall and he stood upright. He watched her, his head nodding almost imperceptibly. He turned his back to her, put both hands in his pockets again. He was looking out to the hall where he'd come in.

He said, "I thought this would be easier."

"What would?" she said, buttoning up her pants, pulling her zip.

"I thought you'd want to see me."

She didn't answer him, did her belt up, looked at his big body, how it filled out the suit, watched his profile as his eyes went around her house.

"Pete's doing well, I see," he said.

"What are you doing here?"

"I'm not doing too bad now, Jess, either." He still spoke away from her, spoke to the room. "Six figures. Salary and commission. Maybe I never should have been a teacher."

"Why would you come here?" she said, folding her arms over her chest so he wouldn't see her nipples standing out.

"Got the nerve, finally. Coming through Ohio again. I travel all over. Coming through here...I looked you up."

"We're over..."

He huffed. "I find you. I watch you. Can't believe what I'm seeing. I've been here three days now..."

She felt a cold tingle of dread, a thatch of fiery needles rushing up her neck and through her hair, all over her scalp. She didn't speak.

He turned, not to her, but a fraction away from her. Pointed to the kitchen.

"Tyler, no," she whispered.

He went to the baby gate and she followed him. Tyler squat down, his fingers weaving through the rungs, draped over the top and he peered at Annabelle.

She said, “Hi-ii.”

“Hi,” Tyler said, “What’s your name?”

“Annabelle,” she said.

“Hi, Annabelle,” he said. He held his big index finger out to her and she gripped it.

Jess collapsed to her knees behind him, her knees cracking on the maple.

“Don’t,” she cried, “please, don’t.”

Tyler said to Annabelle, “You’re so pretty, Annabelle.”

“Fank you,” she said and she held the top rail of her baby gate, either side of his hand that read FREE.

He turned to Jess then and put a knee on the floor, he looked at her with a serious firm look. “Is she mine?”

“No, Tyler,” she said, looking as fierce as she could. “She’s Pete’s.”

“She has my eyes,” he said, looking to Annabelle again and giving her his finger to hold.

“She has *my* eyes, Tyler. She has *my* eyes,” she hissed.

Tyler shook his head angrily, stood up and reached over the gate and hoisted baby Annabelle up to him, hands under her arms so he could look in her face. He kissed Annie’s cheek.

Jess covered her mouth and her nose as she watched. Exploding inside, wanting to cry but afraid to do anything, afraid to speak, afraid to move. She watched in horror. He settled her then against his chest, held her to him and she rested.

“How could you, Jess?”

“She’s Pete’s. She—”

“Jess, how could you?”

She shook her head and breathed into her hands, felt her lips tremble against her palms.

“You know,” he said, his head shaking, mad, stopping, then continued, “You know...my time with you...that was the best time in my life...”

“Don’t say that,” she whispered through her hands.

“If she’s a product of that, Jess...” He shook his head and looked up to the cathedral ceiling of the kitchen. His eyes were wet with emotion.

“Get out,” she whispered.

He cleared his throat. Said, “I’m going.” Then to Annie, he said, “You want to say bye?”

She smiled and hid her face against his chest like she was shy and she said *Bye-e* into his suit jacket.

“Oh man,” Tyler sighed. “Nice to meet you, Annabelle. I’ll see you.” He set her down on the other side of the gate and she plopped to her butt then crawled to her piggies.

Jess’s tears came now and she cried, “She’s Pete’s baby, okay?” She brushed them away.

Tyler said, “Don’t cry, Jess.” He reached out to hold her shoulder with his hand but she pushed it away.

“Just go,” she said, more tears streaming down her cheeks.

He put his hands back in his pocket and he headed for her hall. She followed him, went past the picture he’d held when he came in, followed him right to the door getting angrier at him with every step. Coming in here like he did. Thinking he could say the things he said.

At the door he turned to speak and she lashed out in fury. She thumped his shoulder with her balled fist, striking him four times like she had a hammer. She yelled, “You never came back! You never came back! I don’t want you any more! Get out, just get out!”

He flinched and raised his shoulder to protect his face, held a hand up to block her if she tried. “Stop, Jess, stop,” he said and he watched her hands,

grabbed her wrists then and held them steady, looking in her eyes. “Stop,” he repeated.

When she was still, and they held each other’s eyes for too long a moment he kissed her. His lips came to hers and she kissed him. Her lips were tight and stiff and closed but he pressed his to hers and she twisted her face up in remorse but she didn’t pull away. He let her go then, stepped back and looked her up and down. Then he left. Opened the door, stepped out to their brick stoop and walked down the manicured walkway that Pete had snipped with shears just this last Saturday morning. They were beginning to bud. She watched him walk all the way out to their driveway, out onto the cul-de-sac and get into a lifted pickup truck parked in front of their house. It started up with a mechanical rumble, exhaust shaking and clattering. She thought he might hammer out of here, squeal and roar, but he put it in gear and the truck eased itself out to the stop sign at the end of the street, signaled then turned left. She closed the door and she got down on her knees and she cried.

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